REDMOND TECH ORCHESTRA

RACH FEST

MEYDENBAUER CENTER THEATRE

TCHAIKOVSKY Slavonic March

RACHMANINOFF Symphonic Dances (1st movement)

Rhapsody on a Theme of Paganini Piano Concerto No. 2

April 3, 2025

7pm
(doors open @ 6:30)

aka.ms/mooconcert

Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky	Slavonic March in B♭ minor, Op. 31	10’
Sergei Rachmaninoff	Symphonic Dances (1st mvt.), Op. 45	12’
	Rhapsody on a Theme of Paganini, Op. 43	24’
	Diana Guo	
	Intermission	
	Piano Concerto No. 2 in C minor, Op. 18	35’
	Jada Campbell	

Tchaikovsky Composer Spotlight

Born on May 7, 1840, in Votkinsk, Russia, Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky was a prominent composer of the Romantic era. Tchaikovsky’s musical education began at the age of five with piano lessons. He attended concerts with his family complaining, on one occasion, that he could not fall asleep because of the music stuck in his head. In 1862, he enrolled in the newly established St. Petersburg Conservatory, where he studied composition under Anton Rubinstein, one of the most brilliant pianists of the time. He graduated in 1865 and soon became a professor of harmony at the Moscow Conservatory, a position he held until 1878.

During this period, Tchaikovsky composed several significant works, including his First Symphony, the opera Voyevoda, and the very popular overture for Romeo and Juliet. He then began communicating with his future patroness Nadezhda von Meck, who allowed him to retire from teaching and spend more time composing orchestral works.

Despite professional success, Tchaikovsky’s personal life was marked by turmoil and pain. He struggled with his homosexuality, which he kept private, and experienced several personal crises, including the death of his mother at the young age of 14, his failed marriage to Antonina Milyukova, and the collapse of his relationship with his aforementioned patroness. Tchaikovsky died on November 6, 1893, in St. Petersburg.

Tchaikovsky’s legacy endures through his timeless music, which continues to captivate audiences worldwide. Some of his most famous compositions include the ballets Swan Lake, The Nutcracker, and The Sleeping Beauty, as well as the 1812 Overture. His ability to blend Western symphonic traditions with Russian folk elements has made him one of the most beloved and influential composers in classical music history.

Slavonic March

Marche Slave, also known as Slavonic March, is an orchestral tone poem composed by Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky in 1876. The piece was commissioned by the Russian Musical Society to support the Red Cross Society and aid soldiers wounded in the Turko-Serbian war.

The march is structured in four sections: The first section, in B♭ minor, portrays the suffering of the Serbs and incorporates two Serbian folk songs in a dirge-like theme. The second section represents the Russians coming to the Serbs' aid, featuring a rustic dance melody. The third section repeats the orchestral climax from the first section, emphasizing the Serbian call for help. The final section, using a Russian tune this time in B♭ major key, depicts the Russian volunteers marching into battle, culminating in a triumphant rendition of the Russian imperial anthem "God Save the Tsar", and the whole piece finishes with a triumphant coda with the blast of the full orchestra. Marche Slave remains a powerful and evocative work, showcasing Tchaikovsky's ability to blend nationalistic themes and emotionalism in one brilliant orchestral work.

Rachmaninoff Composer Spotlight

Sergei Rachmaninoff was born on April 1, 1873, in Semyonovo, Russia into a musical family–his grandfather had been a student of composer John Field. He was a renowned composer, pianist, and conductor and is celebrated as one of the last great figures of Russian Romanticism. Rachmaninoff's early musical education began with piano lessons from his mother, a trained pianist. He later studied at the Moscow Conservatory, where he excelled in both piano and composition.

At the conservatory, he began his working relationship with Tchaikovsky, who played a significant role as a mentor in Rachmaninoff's early career. Even before graduating, Rachmaninoff had composed one of his most well known works, Prelude in C♯ minor. Tchaikovsky was impressed by the young composer's talent and predicted a great future for him, providing encouragement and support, which were invaluable to Rachmaninoff, who looked up to Tchaikovsky as a father figure.

Rachmaninoff's career was marked by both triumphs and challenges. His First Symphony which premiered in 1897 was a critical failure; most historians blame the conductor Alexander Glazunov. As a result, he experienced a period of depression. Rachmaninoff overcame this setback, however, with the success of his Piano Concerto No. 2 in 1901, which remains one of his most popular works. He dedicated the first movement of this monumental work to Dr. Nikolai Dahl, who had helped treat his depression. In 1918, following the Russian Revolution, Rachmaninoff emigrated to the United States, where he continued to perform and compose.

Rachmaninoff's music is characterized by its sensitivity and expressiveness, often reflecting his own personal struggles and experiences. He passed away on March 28, 1943, in Beverly Hills, California, leaving behind a legacy of timeless music that continues to captivate audiences worldwide.

Symphonic Dances

Composed in 1940, Symphonic Dances is Rachmaninoff's final orchestral work, blending nostalgia, rhythmic vitality, and deep emotional expression. Written after his emigration to the U.S., the piece reflects both his Russian heritage and a modern, forward-looking style. Today, our orchestra is performing the first movement of this three-movement work that showcases Rachmaninoff's signature lyricism, bold orchestration, and rich harmonies.

The first movement, **Non allegro**, begins with sharp, driving energy but soon gives way to a strikingly intimate moment. After a brief pause, the alto saxophone enters with a plaintive, quintessential Russian solo, accompanied by delicate woodwind textures. For nearly three minutes, the winds play alone, creating a sense of both intimacy and distance. When the strings finally join, they bring a fuller, more emotional sound, but this moment is short-lived as the opening energy returns.

The piece, initially considered for a ballet, ultimately became a concert work filled with references to Rachmaninoff's earlier compositions and a personal farewell to his homeland and career.

Rhapsody on a Theme of Paganini

Sergei Rachmaninoff's Rhapsody on a Theme of Paganini, Op. 43, composed in 1934, is a concertante work for piano and orchestra. The piece is structured as a set of 24 variations on the 24th and final caprice of Niccolò Paganini, a theme that has inspired numerous composers including Brahms, Schumann, and Liszt due to its virtuosic nature. Something to listen for in this piece is the use of the Dies Irae chant, which appears in a few of the variations, adding a sense of foreboding and drama.

The "Rhapsody" is divided into three sections, resembling the traditional concerto form:

1. The first section **(Variations 1-10)** corresponds to the first movement, featuring the theme and its initial variations. The piece begins with steady energy and growing complexity, echoing Brahms. A shift occurs as the Dies Irae chant introduces a dark force, symbolizing the evil spirit in Paganini's legend. The theme intensifies, culminating in bold, marcato octaves.
2. In the second section **(Variations 11-18)**, the music shifts to a dreamy, romantic mood, introducing a woman through a graceful dance. A passionate dialogue follows, growing into an intense waltz with martial undertones. A piano solo leads to a slower, evolving exploration of the theme, culminating in a lyrical nocturne—Rachmaninoff's "ultimate love episode"—in the famous 18th variation.
3. The third section **(Variations 19-24)** acts as the finale, building to a riveting and energetic conclusion. The music grows more technical and intense, with lively pizzicati and rapid motion. A scherzo-like struggle unfolds between Paganini and the evil spirit, leading to a powerful climax. The Dies Irae theme resounds before a sudden, quiet conclusion.

Rachmaninoff's Rhapsody premiered on November 7, 1934, with the composer himself as the soloist, accompanied by the Philadelphia Orchestra conducted by Leopold Stokowski. The piece was an immediate success and has since become a staple repertoire.

Piano Concerto No. 2

Sergei Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 2 in C minor, Op. 18, is one of his most celebrated works. Composed between 1900 and 1901, the concerto marked Rachmaninoff's triumphant return to composition after a period of deep depression following the disastrous premiere of his First Symphony. The first part of the concerto is dedicated to Dr. Nikolai Dahl, the physician who helped Rachmaninoff overcome his writer's block through hypnotherapy.

The concerto is structured in three movements:

1. **Moderato:** The first movement opens with a series of powerful piano chords, leading into a lyrical and expansive theme. The interplay between the piano and orchestra creates a sweeping and impassioned narrative.
2. **Adagio sostenuto:** The second movement is known for its lyrical beauty and romantic character, an abrupt departure from the stormy first movement. It features a dialogue between the piano and orchestra, with a central theme heard in the oboe and violas that has become iconic. The third movement immediately follows the end of this with no break.
3. **Allegro scherzando:** The final movement begins with a distant march which builds up to the piano's authoritative entrance. The work continues with the march music with liveliness and determination while showcasing Rachmaninoff's technical prowess as a pianist. It culminates in a triumphant and exhilarating conclusion.

The concerto premiered on November 9, 1901, with Rachmaninoff himself as the soloist, and it was met with great acclaim. The work has since become a dominant part of the piano repertoire, admired for its emotional profundity, technical demands, and indelible melodies. The second movement, in particular, has been widely used in popular culture, including in the film Brief Encounter and the song All By Myself (Eric Carmen). Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 2 remains a testament to his resilience and artistic genius, continuing to captivate audiences worldwide.

Soloist Biographies

Diana Gao is a Senior Marketing Manager at Microsoft. She started playing the piano at age 4, and has garnered numerous accolades in prestigious competitions, including First Prize at the "Golden Classical Music Awards" International Competition, which led to a solo performance at Carnegie Hall, a Gold Medalist in the Seattle International Piano Competition, and more. She's been actively performing throughout the country.

In addition to her musical achievements, she's a dedicated Board member of Classical KING, and an event committee member of Seattle Symphony. Since 2020, she has presented annual fundraising recitals through the Microsoft Give campaign, raising significant funds for local non-profit organizations. Those events reinforced her belief that music has the power to inspire change and make the world a better place.

Jada Campbell is a distinguished concert pianist who has captivated audiences around the world with her profound musicality and technical brilliance. Known for her expressive interpretations and dynamic stage presence, Jada has established herself as a formidable artist in the classical music world. Jada's solo performances have graced prestigious venues, including the American Protégé International Piano Competition at Weill Recital Hall, Carnegie Hall in New York City; the Chapelle du Verona in France; Cohen-Davidson Hall in Baltimore, and the Plaza de Corona in Cremona.

A passionate chamber musician, Jada has performed in renowned festivals such as the Zodiac Music Festival in Valdeblore, France, and the Cremona International Music Festival in Italy. A graduate of the Peabody Conservatory with a Bachelor of Music in Piano Performance, Jada studied under the esteemed Brian Ganz.

Jada currently is the principal keyboardist for the Redmond Tech Orchestra, and previously performed Gershwin's "Rhapsody in Blue" as a soloist with the Redmond Tech Orchestra in July 2024.

Jada also works as a product manager at Microsoft, creating user experiences for the most popular products in Azure.

Musician Roster

Violin I
Isabel Milewski
Concertmaster
Jerry He
Assistant Concertmaster
Audra Stump
Bonnie You
Bryan Reich
Jennifer Deng
Madeleine Jacobitz
Mirabai Smoot

Violin II
Brandon Chen
Principal
Erica Choi
Assistant Principal
Alan Zhu
Amy Ouyang
Farrah Hasen
Gabriel Mallari
Michelle Ding
Myra Ramdenbourg
Rachael Tang
Riley Dyer
Sophie Zhao
Trevor Jones

Viola
Jacob Park
Principal
Henry Wang
Assistant Principal
Eleanor Mengel
Stephanie Xie
Sumit Choudhury

Violoncello
Adrian Pang
Principal
Rodrigo Ramirez
Assistant Principal
Alaina Bossert
Aleksandar Boljanac
Dorian Latchague
Lotus Kam Chow
Sabrina Ang
Taylor Thackaberry

Double Bass
Alex Hansen
Principal
Supriya Dixit
Tanya Lai

Flute
Jennifer Lee
Principal
Alex Ayala*
Assistant Principal
Alejandro Rios
Assistant Principal
Britania Rodriguez Reyez
Kathy Smythe
Nandhini Lakuduva*
Robin Goldstein*
Stephanie Luck
Yueh Tsao

Piccolo
Alex Ayala*
Nandhini Lakuduva*
Robin Goldstein*

Oboe
Jennifer Williams
Principal
Vikas Barevadia

English Horn
Rebecca Williams

Clarinet
Emily You
Co-Principal
Helen Xiong
Co-Principal
David Chen
Iris He
Joanna Chu*
Michael Taylor
Moe Tsuboike
Renee Hsu
Tom Glanz

Bass Clarinet
Joanna Chu*
Principal

Bassoon
Joshua Schnipke
Principal
Emily Jin
Shannon Nelson

Contrabassoon
Titan Rodick

Alto Saxophone
Ethan Wong*

French Horn
Caeli MacLennan
Co-Principal
Andrew Schuck
Co-Principal
Chris Hansen
Linda Brooking

Trumpet
Sven Boemer
Principal
Ayush Vikram
Bradley Harrison
Ethan Wong*

Trombone
Cole Brooking
Principal
Conall Anderson
Johnny Leek
Stefan Smolen
Zach Neely

Tuba
Adithya Subbiah*
Principal

Timpani
Thomas Tavarez
Principal

Percussion
Matthew Kangas
Principal
Aaryaa Tiwari
Enrique Saurez
Jacob Pierce
Nicholas Vadasz

Keys
Eduardo Ceja Cruz
Joanna Chu*

*Doubling

About the Orchestra

We are the Redmond Tech Orchestra (RTO), a group primarily composed of tech employees (from data scientists, software engineers, to program managers and UX designers) who share a passion for music. Our mission is to create a vibrant cultural environment, support musical education, and make orchestral performances accessible to everyone. Founded in January 2024, we have grown from a small group of employees into a diverse portfolio of ensembles, including a jazz band, woodwind quintet, and various additional chamber groups. Our musicians come from many different backgrounds and skill sets, but we have built a truly lasting community of friends through the orchestra. This is our fourth public concert, and we have also performed at various community events such as park gatherings, fundraising events, Lunar New Year Festivals, and Black History Month celebrations.

Donation

As a nonprofit organization, the Redmond Tech Orchestra relies on your generous donations to continue bringing music to the community. Your support helps us organize events and foster a love for music in the greater Redmond area. Please consider donating to help us keep the music alive. Every contribution, no matter the size, makes a significant impact.

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Upcoming Concert

Join us for an unforgettable evening of music on July 19th at the Overlake Christian Church as we present a concert themed around some of the most beloved movies and musicals. Our talented performers, accompanied by a choir, will take you on a journey through iconic scores from Jurassic Park, La La Land, Wicked, West Side Story, Phantom of the Opera, and more!

Redmond Tech Orchestra @redmondtechorchestra

redmondtechorchestra.org